

Complimentary Copy

THE REVOLUTIONARY BHOODAN



A
Collection of speeches
and writings of

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संदर्भ विभाग

S-1-30



SARVODAYA PRACHIN ALAYA, TANJORE.

the Akhila Bharath Sarva Seva Sangh)

Price Annas Six



This is the revised edition of our previous booklet which appeared under the title "The Revolutionary Bhoodan Yagna". Retaining most of the collections in the previous edition we have enlarged the booklet by including the latest speeches of Shri J. C. Kumarappa at Puri Sarvodaya Sammelan and of Shri. C. Rajagopalachariar and Shri. Dharendra Mazumdar at the Tamil Nad Sarvodaya Sammelan in June 1955 which will throw more light on the movement.

Though the central concept and the ideal of the Bhoodan are one they have been presented from various angles which are edited under the following heads.

Bhoodan, An Economic Agrarian
Revolution

The Bhoodan Movement

Appeal to Students

Bhoodan Revolution

Total Destruction or Sarvodaya

Bhoodan for World Peace

Bhoodan—the Movement of compassion

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The Basis of Sarvodaya

Bhoodan—The way of Sharing

India's Soul is Astir

Tanjore,)
10—5—'55 }

Sarvodaya Prachuralaya

(Akhila Bharath Sarva Seva Sangh)

Bhoodan An Economic Agrarian Revolution

DR. S. RADHAKRISHNAN

ACHARYAJI started his discourse with a vedic prayer* that we may all grow one in mind, one in heart, one in purpose. That is the prayer with which he started his discourse this evening. We have had this prayer coming down to us for centuries. We cannot say that we have developed unity of mind, heart or purpose. While the ideal which we held before us commanded our allegiance intellectually, in practice we have deviated from it. If the success of our civilisation is due to the dominance of this ideal the failure of our civilisation is due to the departure from these ideals. It is true that we have survived—survived many other civilisations which have passed away. If you want to understand those other civilisations you have to study really the ruins where jackals howl in the moonlight. But so far as Indian civilisation is concerned, the very fact that we have an assembly like this and a number of distinguished exponents of Indian culture brought together on the day, it makes you feel that the culture is alive.

Acharyaji has started this Bhoodan Yagna. There are many people who think that in our country we want salvation or *mukti*, and every individual high or low, caste or outcast, has the liberty to attain Nirvan. But Nirvan does not mean liberation from the body. One of the Upanishads tells you: “Pranaramam Manaanandam, Santhi Samrudham, Amrutham”.

* Samani Vah Akutihi Samana Hridayani Vah
Samanamsthu Vo Mano Yadha Vah Susahasati

"Amrita" or life eternal is "Pranaramam", the play of physical light, "Mana Anandam", satisfaction of the mind, "Shanti Samrudham", the tranquillity of spirit. Therefore, life eternal means an all-round awakening, a Sarvodaya, so to say, of all the powers of the human being. It is an all-round development of the human being. "Pranaramam" is the first thing, the play of the vital organism, the play of light. Body is not a thing to be neglected. It is a thing to be cultivated. When the Yoga Sutra Acharya tells us how we are to attain Samadhi the first condition he puts is 'Develop your physique'. He points out to us: 'rupa—lavanya—bala—vajra Samhananathvani Kayasampat'.

"The physical prowess consists in the development of beauty, of radiance, of strength, of invulnerability". Unless you develop your physical basis nothing else is possible for you. You cannot have intellectual development or spiritual development unless you provide for the material basis of life.

Bhoodan, in trying to bring about an economic agrarian revolution by enabling all our individuals, all the citizens who are engaged in agriculture, to share some land which they can use for their purposes, is attempting to provide for this very essential basis of any other kind of development. Aristotle also says :

"We must live before we can live well and life means the provision of the material necessities".

I may incidentally point out that this agrarian revolution will also help to eliminate the differences of caste and outcast, which are polluting, corrupting, so to say, our atmosphere. There is no one who can get up and

say that the observance of these distinctions is in accordance with religion, or social morality. If religion tells us one thing it is this. Here, in this place, Bodh-Gaya, we have to remember what both the Hindu, the Buddhist and the Jaina scriptures have declared. The Hindu scripture says "*Thathvamasi*", "That art thou". Each human individual has the spark of the Divine. It does not say, only the Brahmin has the spark divine, or the outcast has it, or the rich has it, or the poor has it. It says all men by virtue of their humanity have the possibilities of growing into the divine stature. The Divine is there stationed as a possibility in every human being. The Buddha told us that everyone can become a Buddha, can develop Bodhi or enlightenment. There is no one who is prevented from the realisation of that possibility. So also the Jains tell us that everyone can become *Arhata*. The Jews declared that the spirit of man is the candle of the Lord. Jesus tells us "The Kingdom of God is within you".

St. Paul says: "Know ye not that you are the temple of God and the Spirit of God dwelleth in you". Islam proclaims that God is nearer to us than the very artery to our neck. Well, while all these religions with one voice are proclaiming the divine nature of the human being how can anyone get up and say that the practice of caste distinctions or the practice of untouchability are to be regarded as consistent with religion? It is opposed to religion, there is no doubt about it. Again turn to Ethics. What do you mean by Ethics? Ethics simply declare "*Paropakara*" is *punya*, and "*Parapeedana*" is *papa*. 'Parapeedana' does not mean merely inflicting a bodily injury. Doing violence to the dignity of another human

being is doing violence to him in the most tender part of his nature. He is a sacred being. He has his own dignity and anyone who offends by saying that these things are not to be provided for you, those other things are to be given for you, is practising something which is unethical.

And what does our social Dharma say? Dharma is that which binds society together or Adharma is that which breaks society asunder. Anything which makes for the consolidation of society is Dharma; anything which makes for the disintegration of society is Adharma. If in this human history of ours we have suffered many defeats, may I say that it is not suffering imposed on an innocent being, it is not a crucifixion that we have had, we have suffered for the sins we have committed.

There is such a thing as the logic of history. The world is bound by the law of Karma. Nations rise or fall according to their great qualities or their opposite. So, we must realise that if you practise anything which leads to the decomposition or the disintegration of the society you are doing something which is Adharma. If you do anything which brings people together you are doing something which is Dharma. Dharma is that which makes for social coherence. Therefore, I ask, I plead with you, that if you are truly religious, if you are truly ethical, if you are believers in social morality, then practices like these will have to be eliminated. They bring this whole country and our religion into disgrace. No one can get up and say that these are the things which are furnished by our religions.

*(A speech delivered at the Sixth Sarvodaya
Sammelan at Bodh-Gaya on 19-4-1954)*

THE BHOODAN MOVEMENT

SHANKARRAO DEO

THE outside world has heralded the Bhoodan Movement or the sacrifice of the land-offering movement of Acharya Vinoba Bhave in India as a marvellous one. It seems almost a miracle to many.

Acharya Vinoba and many of his followers go about walking and appealing to the landed people to part with a portion of their land to the landless in the Village. The call goes and many respond immediately, both the rich and the poor.

The Sarvodaya Samaj and the Sarva Seva Sangh are the two institutions that came into existence, immediately after Gandhiji's demise, at a conference of his followers in Sevagram in April 1948. The Samaj and the Sangh were considered to be the fittest memorials to carry on the message of Gandhiji's life and work. The Samaj represents the Sarvodaya concept and the Sangh is the executive body to implement the programme that may be considered at the annual conferences of the Sarvodaya Samaj.

It was at the annual conferences of the Sarvodaya Samaj at Banaras in 1952 that the Sangh decided to collect 25 lakhs of acres of land by April 1954, through the Bhoodan Yagna.

There is a uniqueness in this Yagna unknown to history. The world is familiar with violent movements to bring about revolution. But all those were revolutions

of the environments only and left the individual man untouched in his heart and mental outlook. The uniqueness of the Bhoodan Yagna is its straight appeal to the heart and conscience of man. It appeals to the inherent goodness in man. This is a social technique never tried till now on a mass scale. It was Mahatma Gandhi who evolved and handled it on a nation-wide basis for the political liberation of India.

After Gandhiji, the problem of economic freedom or economic equality and justice, remained to be solved still. India had discarded the traditional method of violence and used the non-violent method in her struggle for political freedom. How to continue the Gandhian revolution in the economic sphere was the problem.

Now, economic freedom will be airy nothing unless the worker owns the means of production of the essentials of his subsistence. Therefore everyone, who can till, should be made the owner of the land he needs for his existence. Gandhiji had, of course, the land problem always in his mind. He hoped and said that the Zamindars would one day give away their lands voluntarily to the landless. Some thought that it may be easy and satisfied themselves with resolutions passed in conferences.

But the total transformation of the human heart and mental revolutions cannot be brought about by mere resolutions and appeals. It requires a man who is fully charged with spiritual life, as appeals from him alone can serve as a lever for such revolutions.

It was given to Acharya Vinoba Bhave to take a lead in this problem. He was deeply absorbed in the land problem and in finding a non-violent solution to it. He was as if spiritually qualifying himself for extending the Gandhian revolution in the economic sphere, when the call comes.

He had been making various experiments for years in his Ashram at Paunar, 6 miles from Wardha. All were directed to the one object of liberating man from the clutches of money and making him live independently on his own labour. When invited to the Sarvodaya Conference in 1951, consistent with his principle, he walked the distance to Hyderabad of about 350 miles. On his return to Wardha he walked, without the military protection which the Government offered, into the heart of Telangana area which, you know, was the victim of popular violence on one side and the police methods of putting it down on the other. He walked into this area carrying the message to all—the message of peace, love and unbending courage.

Somewhere in his walk an incident happened which threw a ray of light for Vinobaji. It was in Pochampalli village.* After his usual talk at the meeting, some Harijans said that they were tillers of the soil but had no land of their own to till. Vinobaji paused and thought that there should be someone in the audience who could satisfy the hunger of the landless in their own midst. He appealed to the audience and one Ramachandra Rao immediately came forward offering 100 acres of land. The needy Harijans were satisfied.

*On 18th April 1951

To the people there this might have appeared as a miraculous incident of momentary importance. But to Vinoba this was more than that. To him this seemed to convey a guidance from God. If one man could be moved by the need of the landless, why not all those who have, be also moved to give away to the millions of the needy? His faith in God and in human goodness made him hope to tap this invisible perennial resource in every human heart. From the very next day he began to pursue the Bhoodan Yagna—the new way that God had indicated to him to move forward in the footsteps of his great master.

His mastery of this technique and marvellous use with an exposition of the basic philosophy behind Bhoodan have produced remarkable results. All those who were then sceptical have accepted it now as the only way open to us to deal with the land problem. Persons of all parties except, of course, those who have no faith in human goodness have begun to give their full support to this great Yagna. The State Governments are giving their support to the movement by making the necessary legislation for facilitating the voluntary transfer and distribution of land as well as by offering any available State land to the Bhoodan movement.

To the outside world this is almost impossible to believe. But it is daily happening in India today. It is but natural and consistent with the spiritual and cultural heritage and genius of India that those who have land readily offer a portion to the landless when someone could touch their heart. Gandhiji had already

tilled and ploughed the Indian soil during the last thirty years for such a non-violent action. We first reaped the harvest of political freedom. It only required another great man to plough again and sow the seed for the harvest of the economic freedom of the masses. Here was Vinobaji who gave the lead at the proper time.

This Bhoodan Yagna is but the logical outcome of the Sarvodaya philosophy and approach. Gandhiji's philosophy and technique of action were based on the perennial philosophy of truth and non-violence.

The Sarvodaya Samaj was formed, as I told you, as the fittest memorial to Gandhiji. This magical word '*Sarvodaya*' was coined by Gandhiji himself. Sarvodaya means the total welfare of all, to the exclusion of none. This will be possible only by purity of means and a way and value of life based on truth and non-violence.

The Bhoodan Yagna, therefore, aims at a total transformation of man by change of his heart and mind. Bhoodan is not an end in itself but a key to the solution of the other economic problems with a view to create a new order of society, free from any kind of exploitation of man by man, in all spheres of life—economic, social and political.

(*A Radio Talk at Colombo on 25-6-1953 with
Courtesy to THE RADIO CEYLON*)



APPEAL TO STUDENTS

JAIPRAKASH NARAIN

NOW-A-DAYS, generally speaking, my experience is that the students of the colleges and high schools are attracted towards either socialism or communism or communalism or movements based on communal ideologies as of the Rashtriya Swayam Sevak Sangh or towards the Dravidian Youth League of South India etc. I have seen this happen in my youth during the years 1921—22. At that time the Gandhian tempest raged over the country and the youths were all swept off their feet. But now-a-days the youths are of opinion that the ways of Gandhiji are old-fashioned. They say that Gandhiji's ways cannot appeal to them in this age of the atom bomb, and of revolutionary Russia and China. Perhaps the youths assembled here think differently and have been influenced by Sarvodaya.

I would prefer not to say anything regarding the leaders of communism and communalism, but I would have my say regarding socialism. I have been asked whether I have been able to reconcile Sarvodaya and Socialism in my own mind. This question arises before those of the socialist persuasion, as for instance, the students.

If you understand the aims of Socialism, forgetting its theories for the moment, and bestow some serious thought on its aims alone, it would not be difficult for you to understand how we can very easily make both Sarvodaya and Socialism meet together. What we

desire is the establishment of a society in which there will be no exploitation, there will be perfect equality and each individual will have equal opportunities for development. So the question of attaining these ends, and realising these aims arises. We have seen that wherever attempts were made to achieve these aims through violent means, these aims were not realised, exploitation was not removed, equality was not established and the individual did not gain full opportunities for development.

Wherever a new order was brought about through a violent revolution we see an entirely new thing taking shape. Very often what we desire is to destroy the present established order of things and imagine that thereby we are bringing in the new order. The Socialists think that no sooner had we destroyed capitalism than the new order will get established. But in this they are mistaken. Socialism is not a negative thing. Take for instance nationalisation which is a plank of Socialism. Nationalisation alone will not bring in the Socialistic order. We have seen this in our own country and in other countries as well. Leave alone the case of Russia; our Railways today belong to all, they are no longer the possession of a company but they are the property of the entire nation, But if we are to say that the Railway administration is free from exploitation we would be mistaken. True, there is no capitalism now; neither is there Socialism. What is ruling there is bureaucracy. Similarly if we say that by nationalising the other industries we will be ushering in Socialism we would only be deceiving ourselves. How then are we to get at the reality? How

to proceed so far? We are now faced with this question. But Sarvodaya has already taken long strides in the direction in which we are proceeding, in which our thinking is taking us. Therefore if we are true Socialists we would be true followers of Sarvodaya as well.

We say that every individual has got the right to take part in the governance of the country. Answering a query as to how true democracy can be established, Vinoba has declared that it is essential to establish village government. And if we are true socialists we should also proclaim our faith in village autonomy. Thus are the two streams of thought meeting together. While some people make fun of my attendance at this conference, my participation in it and my admiration for Vinobaji, there are others who say, "so you have come round at last!" But the time has come now for all of us to think truthfully, deeply and courageously. Any true socialist who strives day and night for realising his aims, will find himself in the same position that I find myself in today.

Let us take into account Gandhiji and Vinobaji. All the others belong to a different category. There was a time when none was able to say how to proceed and where. The common people were then under the expectation that the close followers of Gandhiji would show the way to transform society which Gandhiji would of course have done, had he been alive. But after his exit, the entire prospect was one of utter darkness. My own impression is, had not Vinobaji launched the Bhoodan Yagna campaign we would have forgotten Gandhiji and forgotten Sarvodaya; we would have lost

faith in what Gandhiji had said and done and the path of Sarvodaya would have been blocked. Vinobaji has infused new life by placing the Bhoodan Yagna programme before us. Otherwise the constructive workers would have continued ploughing their lonely furrows. This would have certainly benefited the country to some extent but the hope of the common man that the followers of Gandhiji would take steps for the transformation of the country, would have been shattered and an armed revolution would have ensued with entirely different consequences. Therefore we should take to this method in order to achieve the aims we cherish. Let us, forgetting our self-importance and the prestige of the party, get down to work.

I place all these things before the students purposely because they are all faced with the same question and they are in a dilemma. It seems to them that we are going astray. We should very sincerely keep our aims before our eyes and achieve them. The aims we have, are not our sole monopoly ; they are claimed by others also ; but our means are different. So Shankarrao Deoji said just now and he is right. If the aim is to establish a society which will be free from exploitation and if that is achieved through violent means the aim will still remain unrealised. Violence sets in motion new forms of exploitation. Exploitation signifies the denial to one of his rights. We cannot expect the complete removal of exploitation. Even today the level of our own life is far higher than that of our brethren ; so it cannot be denied that we have exploited them. You are today engaged in your studies ; much money is being spent on

you. Such expense cannot be incurred by the poor over the education of their children. So a part of the responsibility for the exploitation rests on you. Perhaps to hope for the complete removal of exploitation is to hope for the impossible. But we should pursue that ideal and have our limits defined. Even in Russia differences do exist; the high-paid drawing forty times as much as the low-paid. The level of life lived by the officials is very high; so exploitation is far from being extinct there. Because they gained power through violence, by the same means they decide the share of the fruits of labour that should go to each. The society which is truly free from exploitation can be created only through non-violence. Hence I have no objection in replacing the name of Socialism by the name Sarvodaya.

I have been questioned regarding trusteeship. When Gandhiji went to U.P. in 1935, the Zamindars of the place met him and asked him what their fate would be under the rule of the Congress-Socialist party which had just then been formed. Gandhiji replied "I cannot prophesy what will happen when the Socialists would have gained dominance over the Congress; but I will not be a party to your extinction so long as you conduct yourselves as trustees of your lands".

I was really put out when I heard this and told my colleagues that Gandhiji was telling this to those very Zamindars who were committing so many atrocities on the poor. He wanted them to become trustees and assured them that he would not allow their removal. The meaning of all this is, neither are they going to become trustees nor would Gandhiji allow their destruc-

tion. We believed in those days that this ideal of trusteeship would remain only on paper; it would never be acted upon. But today I am seeing in Gaya where a *bhiga* of land is worth between two to six thousand rupees, people have given their lands. Some 48 thousand acres have been given away. Regarding Gandhiji's pet theories, Kishorlal Bhai once wrote :

“We are mistaken in thinking that the ideals he is expounding are never going to be practised. It appears to us, that Gandhiji may exhort the wealthy to become trustees; but (if the wealthy were not wise) they are not going to do any such thing. The social set-up and its poverty will continue as they are. But if we view Gandhiji in this light, we will be committing a big blunder”.

Were he alive today he would himself have taken up the work that Vinoba has undertaken. What is more probable is, he would have done it much earlier and his manner of doing it would have been more attractive. Gandhiji was saying, that we welcome those who would behave as trustees; if they will not we will prepare the poor and ask them not to cooperate in self-exploitation. Thus will we prepare both? Similarly in the Bhoodan Yagna both the donar and the beneficiary are being prepared. To the extent that Bhoodan Yagna gets popularised, the exploited in the villages will be awakened and they would begin to think of opposing exploitation through non-violent means. So if we simply brush aside the trusteeship idea on the plea that nobody is going to act up to it we would be committing a great blunder. After all, do not even the socialists think of conflicts and class-wars? The working people are not

armed with pistols or bombs ; when they think in terms of general strikes which according to their belief will make the castle of capitalism topple down, a certain amount of violence is unavoidable in the process.

When I see the young people today I am reminded of those days when I was studying in the Patna College. At that time Maulana Abul Kalam Azad had come to Patna and I heard his non-co-operation speech. His speech made us all leave our college. The revolution that took place in the mind of the youths then was not due to any other cause in the same measure as to Gandhiji's movement. A similar revolution is in the offing today. I have not till now heard a speech comparable with the one* that Vinoba delivered yesterday. He presented the matter before us as he viewed it from the philosophical stand-point. Whoever has grasped its significance is sure to have his life transformed. I am having some contacts with the youths and their present condition makes me depressed. They have enthusiasm, but it appears to me that they are lacking in faith, concentration and mental depth.

If the seeds of Sarvodaya have fallen in your mind and intellect, you will remove these defects and you will remember your duty by the performance of which yourself and the society to which you belong will be equally benefited. Vinoba has said that even if you are not to join the Bhoodan Movement, you should leave your colleges. It is impossible that a scholar of his

* Vinobaji's speech on 7-3-'53 is as it were a
'Sarvodaya Manifesto' (published in SARVODAYA)

stature to have become an enemy of learning. Why then did he say this? Because the kind of education that is being given today is beneficial neither to the student nor to the society nor again to the country. Such is the present condition. So no effort should be spared towards the realisation of our duty to the maximum extent.

We are living in stirring times comparable to 1921. Revolution is afoot. Let us take our share in it. Let us prepare ourselves for it. I want you all to give up your studies; go and wander about in the villages and make what contributions you can to the Bhoodan Movement and try to make this revolution a success.

Why hesitate to leave college for a year? I have seen in America many students studying for a term and working during the next for earning the means for further studies. I had then become a convert to communism and having decided on a trip to Russia I had left college and was in search of a job which would fetch me enough to make the trip. But those were days of depression and unemployment was on the increase. I wandered continuously, was prepared for any odd job, but I could not secure any. Then I fell ill, incurred some debt in consequence, but cleared it all later by working. On looking back from this distance it does not appear to me that I lost anything by losing a year at the college. I have never felt that what I learnt in fields and factories was inferior or negligible instruction. The experiences that I gained there could never have been had in colleges. Similarly the education you will receive from the villages can never be got

from schools and colleges. And I believe that if your parents are concerned about your future, about the development of your personality they will of their own accord say—"All right, my dear boy, go and work for a year". It is expected of everyone that he dedicates himself to Bhoodan Yagna for a year. People are giving away their lands and let us give our time and energy. Vinoba says what a revolution it would be, a revolution that would set an example to the whole world if we succeeded in solving the big problem of land through truly democratic method! If we succeed in solving the big problem of land in a big province like Bihar within a year, it will have far-reaching consequences. So we invite you all to join hands in this revolution and hope and trust that the youth of the country will not fail to take to this road.



BHOODAN AND REVOLUTION

J. B. KRIPALANI

FROM its beginning in Hyderabad, the Bhoodan Movement had a fascination for me. From study of history and participation in one revolutionary movement, I saw in it the elements of a comprehensive revolution. I saw in it the possibility of a revival of Gandhiji's ideas and ideals which we have neglected for the past few years. I wrote about the movement in the columns of the Vigil. From the many arguments that I advanced in favour of my thesis I would quote here one only. It is that when a revolutionary movement has once been started, ordinary individuals participating in it perform tasks which were never expected of them. Under the inspiration of a revolutionary urge they work wonders. This can be illustrated both from religious and political history. Christ's followers, ignorant fishermen, could exercise demons, cure the sick, feed the hungry and perform miracles. The Master's grace had descended on them. Ignorant as they were they could hold their own against the cultured and educated of their times. Christ's 'fishermen' became the 'fishers of men'. In Islam, the tribal disciples of the prophet under the impulse of a new idea soon created an empire greater than that of Rome. The semi-civilised people of the desert became the teachers of mankind in philosophy, science and arts.

In the political field, who could have imagined that a Parisian mob hastily formed could under a revolutionary urge storm the Bastille and raze it to the ground! who in

our own days and in our country, before the advent of Gandhi on the political scene, could have believed that thousands of our countrymen, including boys of school-going age and women of high families, who had never stepped out of their homes, would court the privations and hardship of jail, inspired by the idea of the independence of the country! Who could have believed that where great patriots had defended themselves in courts of law against the charge of sedition, every urchin in the street would fearlessly raise the slogan that British rule was satanic and the spread of disaffection against it was a national Dharma. Such historical instances of the ordinary instruments of revolution rising to high heights could be multiplied.

We witness this phenomenon re-appearing today in the Bhoodan movement. In a country where brother fought brother for a few Kathas of land and where such land disputes resulted in murders, today boys and girls scarcely out of their teens go about and ask and obtain a few acres of land every day. You heard how a young Bhoodan volunteer in Gujerat with his patience and perseverance, induced a zamindar, who would not allow him to enter his house, to part with twenty-five acres of land. In Gujerat, twenty-five acres of land would mean at least a couple of lakhs of rupees. Such examples are there in plenty.

Another point that I would keep before you this evening is that there are in history two kinds of revolutions. One seeks to change the life of the individual and community in most of its major department. Another begins with one major department and then proceeds to transform the whole of life.

Buddha and Christ sought to solve the riddle of life. Their mission was purely spiritual. But because their approach to the spiritual problem of the individual was revolutionary, they ultimately succeeded in bringing about comprehensive revolutions. In the wake of the spiritual impulse given by the master, new arts, sciences and systems of philosophy grew up. The political map of the world was changed and new kingdoms and empires were established. Starting from a change in spiritual values the great religions of the world brought about basic changes in other fields of life and activity.

The Bhoodan movement starts with revolutionary ideas about property in land. Yet if it remains at that level it will fail to accomplish even its limited purpose. The movement, if it is truly revolutionary must expand itself to cover all major activities of life. If the landless get a few acres of land and there are a few toddy shops in their midst, their land will evaporate in a few years. If again in spite of land the cultivators were extravagant in their expenditure on birth, marriage, death, etc. and made themselves victims of the rapacious money-lenders, their land would soon disappear. If the village lacks some main and subsidiary industries to provide employment to increasing population, the holdings will be so sub-divided that ultimately they will be of little use to the peasants. Again if the villagers are divided by caste barriers and untouchability, the possession of a few acres of land will scarcely improve their lot. If the Government is bad and tyrannical, corrupt and inefficient, the mere possession of a few acres of land will solve no problems of the villager. If the administration is extravagant and the burden of taxation goes on increas-

ing or if through wrong policies there is inflation the villager will be ruined in spite of his five acres. In short, if the reformer wants the villager really to enjoy the fruits of his newly-acquired land, he must not confine himself merely to the land problem but also tackle the allied social and political problems. In India, before British Raj there were few landless labourers. Almost every villager had a small plot of land. How did these plots disappear? They disappeared because the social and the political arrangements were inimical to their retention. If Bhoodan is to succeed it must work out the whole political, social and economic programme of Bapu.

Today we saw a great step being taken in the movement. Shri Jayaprakash Narayan has announced his 'Jeevandan' for Bhoodan. When he announced his resolve, I too felt tempted to follow his noble example. But a little self-analysis deterred me from taking such a weighty decision. I am known to be prone to anger. I thought if I dedicated my angry self to the movement it may do more harm than good. Only people with some self-control (Samyam) should dedicate their lives for a noble cause. If we suffer from greed, anger, passion, ambition and jealousy, our dedication will be of no avail. Sacrifice to be of value must be pure and without blemish. With the call that Sri Jayaprakash Narayan has given today I hope there will be a re-dedication to the cause.

(From a Speech at Bodh-Gaya on 18-4-1954)



Total Destruction or Sarvodaya?

DHIRENDRA MAZUMDAR

BHOODAN is a new movement with a new foundation, which the world is witnessing today. It has now reached a stage which creates a climate of hope for world peace.

At the Puri Sarvodaya Sammelan in April 1955, Vinobaji had appealed to all our countrymen who were engaged in the constructive activities, to come and join the Bhoodan movement and devote all their time and energy for this work alone, at least for the coming two years. Why did he make this special appeal?

The world situation has become now so explosive that any moment it may burst and blow into a big conflagration which will reduce the entire humanity to ashes. Past history has never witnessed such a crisis or suffered from such a fear tension.

Imagine a house on fire. At once all who see the fire, leave their post of duty and engage themselves in the one and sole service of putting out the flames and rescuing the inmates. They think none of their past differences and quarrels, feel like the members of one common family and jointly work to fight the danger in front. The fire in store in the nuclear weapons manufactured by the scientific advancement and researches of the present day world is there in stock in the corners of the world and the fate of humanity is there in the balance inclined to fall down at any moment to the grave of death and total destruction. Vinobaji clearly

sees this danger at hand and so appeals to all to come to the rescue. Thinkers and philosophers all over the world are crying 'halt' to such scientific advancements resulting in total violence.

Even the common man has come to realise that non-violence is the only power that can save the world from this impending wholesale destruction. Nations are gathering their representatives round Conference-tables for mutual and friendly discussions and negotiations. The talk of "peaceful co-existence" is in the air everywhere.

What do these Governments mean by 'peaceful co-existence'? Is it the co-existence of violence and science? Can these two exist together? There are only two possibilities. Either the onward march of violence with its terrible weapons of destruction should culminate in the total destruction of all life on earth or it should converge and surrender to non-violence, the power of the spiritual force in man and thus usher in a new order of society of equality, peace and prosperity for all. Thus the choice before the world is either *Sarva-nasa* (total destruction) or *Sarvodaya* (welfare of all). Life cannot subsist or enjoy peace in between the two.

The talks of disarmament, control of nuclear energy and harnessing it only to the production of goods of utility value for the welfare of mankind, the ban of nuclear weapons of war, etc., figure most in every international conference. But simultaneously each nation is busy in the progressive increase of its military strength

and power-politics. Thus the cold war is going on and any day it may burst into flames.

Rajaji has been making repeated suggestions to the big nations of the world to behave as good men, destroy all these weapons of destruction, trust their neighbours and establish peace. He points out that unilateral goodness and action on the part of any one nation is sure to produce the necessary moral atmosphere and influence on the others to discard all these deadly weapons of destruction.

But his voice is not listened to by the leaders of the nations. Why? because they have no faith in the power of non-violence. All Governments depend on their police force to put down their internal quarrels and differences. Violent methods alone stand today as the only means to keep the peace inside every nation. Under such conditions, can it be that these international talks of co-existence in the name of peace will bear any result? There is today the clear manifestation of intellectual bankruptcy in every nation of the world. Thus each nation has to strive first to develop the non-violent atmosphere inside, inculcate faith in the people in the power of non-violence, bridge all differences between citizen and citizen by the force of love and persuasion. If they do so, the moral power behind will certainly create an air of mutual trust and love which alone will bring in peace in the world.

Nature abhors vacuum. She will not keep things in suspense. She finds her own remedy. And the message of Bhoodan is there before us. Vinoba says

Bhoodan is the way to World Peace. He sees no time to be lost and wants this revolution to be completed to success before 1957, i. e. in a period of two years. He exhorts the Zamindars to begin handling the ploughs and give up the extra lands in their possession to those who are ready to handle them. He appeals to the owners of wealth to hold their wealth in trust for the common benefit of society and part with a share of their income to supplement the needs of the 'have-nots'. He tells the owners of factories and mills to consider themselves as one with the workmen and enjoy nothing more than what they are morally and equitably entitled. India's tradition and genius is best fitted to demonstrate the power of non-violence and she can certainly show the real way to World Peace.

I appeal to all the workers in the field of various constructive activities to forget all differences between them and take a pledge to live by their own labour. This new way of life we have to begin at once. I may suggest to the workers to spend half a day in assisting the labourers in fields offering physical work and devote the other half in propagating the Sarvodaya ideology of a classless, casteless, non-exploitative society, through Sarvodaya literature.

(Summary of his speech in Hindi made on 4-6-'55 while inaugurating the Tamilnad Third Sarvodaya Sammelan at Thiruthurai-poondi, Tanjore District. Shri C. Rajagopalachariar presided.)



BHOODAN FOR WORLD PEACE

DHIRENDRA MAZUMDAR

THIS morning when we were talking, I casually asked Rajaji on what subject he would be speaking at today's session. With a smile he said "I may talk on B. C. G., and its dangerous effects on human health". I remarked then, "Bhoodan includes B. C. G., also". With this characteristic humour Rajaji added, 'Anything against modern is Bhoodan'.

Thereafter I began to ponder over this remark and began to analyse into what people think as 'modern'. Our people oft repeat that the Gandhites are living thousand years behind, they look askance at every thing that is modern, they close their eyes to the achievements in the advancement of science and its researches and they even refuse to cultivate even a scientific mind, and outlook. I may tell them that we, the Gandhites do respect science and are for its advancement. But at the same time we insist that this advancement should not be to the detriment of human values and spiritual progress. Science should necessarily be wedded to morality. But the modern man thinks that science is the be-all and the end-all and its power is there to be exclusively utilized for producing more and more of material comforts and luxury, with absolutely no respect or consideration for human lives and values. The welfare of human society means to him the raising of the standard of life in the sphere of material comforts alone.

The race for material comforts has made man mad after power to possess the means and weapons of

destruction. This power is assuming the form of *Basmasura* of the Puranas, who in the end, himself brought about his own death and end.

The greed to control the maximum material comforts, each exclusively to himself, has led all nations of the world to live in permanent dread and distrust of the neighbours. Pakistan has allotted Rs. 80 crores out of its income of Rs. 120 crores for defence expenditure. Suppose a family with an income of Rs. 100 were to set apart the major portion of its income for protection against its neighbour whom it fears and distrusts every minute. What will be the tense atmosphere and the nervous strain of its members all through? There can never be, at any moment, in that house peace and happiness. Exactly the same fear tension and neurosis are found today manifested in the life of all nations of the world. It looks as if the she-demon *Puthana* mentioned in our Puranas, has come again to this world in the guise of scientific advancement reaching up to the manufacture of nuclear weapons blatantly ignoring the principles of morality and human values and bent upon bringing total destruction to mankind.

Thinkers and wise men of the world are raising words of warning and offering advices to ban the further manufacture of these terrible weapons of destruction and throw those already stock-piled, in the oceans. Rajaji is again and again appealing to the nations who possess them, for unilateral goodness and act without waiting for others. The Governments of the different nations have begun to realize the gravity of the situation and they join

in conferences to discuss the ways and means to control these deadly weapons of violence.

But these international conferences and discussions will be of no avail so long as the individuals in society do not realize the spiritual strength in them, respect human values and control the brute force in them. There are two forces in man, the force of the strength of his spiritual power and the power of the brute in him. He should first have faith in his moral strength which alone will control the force of the brute might in him. Then alone he can act non-violently and through it solve the various problems confronting him. Bhoodan aims at preparing man for the same and to demonstrate the real power of non-violence to the world. So Vinobaji says that Bhoodan aims at world peace.

(This is a summary of Sri Dhirendra Mazumdar's speech in Hindi made on the Second day of Thiruthuraipoondi Sammelan on 5—6—'55.)



Bhoodan—The Movement of Compassion

C. RAJAGOPALACHARIAR

WE have achieved freedom. We have now to build up our strength. For 150 years we lived as slaves under British rule and for about 1000 years we enjoyed no freedom. To-day we are a free bird liberated from its cage. It will take long before we could establish ourselves.

On many occasions the British rulers told us 'you will be given independence. But you have to become efficient and strong before that'. Many of our own people supported them and said 'yes, we shall wait'. But Gandhiji differed. Because, he disagreed we could become free to-day.

The next step is to strive for our prosperity and happiness. Sarvodaya is the way. Sarvodaya is not a *Potti Udaya* (Rise by competition and conflict). It is the means through which all can become happy. It may be asked 'is not the present Government doing everything needed and that in such a haste and speed that makes them even borrow loans from outside. Then where is the need and what is there for us to worry?' Purity of mind and heart is the fundamental basis of Sarvodaya. It is the absolute rule. Every one and all should try and become pure at heart. No Government can achieve this by its law and regulations.

We should always bear in mind that Sarvodaya is not an institution or organisation. There can be no president or secretary or a committee for it. It is not

a Trust or a Mutt. Is there any institution for the enforcement of such rules of conduct as the mutual affection between father and children, love between the husband and wife to offer food for the hungry who comes to your door, not to utter falsehood etc. etc. etc. Similarly there can be no organisation for Sarvodaya. Sarvodaya is a way of life. If it takes the form of an institution, with president, secretary etc., it means it becomes dead. For Heaven's sake don't make it an institution. Let it remain always a movement to guide the people to follow Dharma.

Sarvodaya includes all that is good. Gandhiji was ambitious to see that every one became good and for that he placed this ideal of Sarvodaya. Sarvodaya takes within itself all constructive activities. Any such activity, if left out or omitted by others the Sarvodaya workers have to take up and fulfil. Land problem is a tough one. Land owners will not easily agree to willingly surrender their rights for others. Hence Bhoodan work is not an easy task. People may easily part with cloth or money for the sake of others. But when it comes to the question of land, they will certainly hesitate. And our Government has left this hard task to Vinoba. The Government has to worry much about its revenue. It is more concerned with the ways and means to collect taxes. So they have left this vexed land problem to Vinoba to be solved. And Vinoba looks to you all for help.

In Vinoba you have the unqualified leader. Gandhiji was an *Avathar* though he himself did not admit it. Vinoba also is an *Avathar* and we are fortunate to have

him in our midst. He is a real Bakta. He has got a keen intellect and none can question the justice of the cause he has taken up. Let us pray to God to bless him with sound health and long life.

Bhoodan movement is not a fight in the sense of a struggle. *Dan* and fight are contradictions in terms. In *dan* there is no place for force or violence which are in fight. This basic difference the workers should well grasp and remember. Such words of intimidation as 'the Government will bring in land legislation which will certainly take away land from you; so you better leave it off now as donation to Bhoodan', amount to compulsion. The workers may well understand that such methods spoil the cause and will kill the work.

Every one should have the basic needs of life. It is against Dharma that some should suffer and others may enjoy. Can it be over imagined for any one to claim ownership over air and water and to demand money to part the same for others' use? America has got a lot of money with her. Can she buy the whole air of the world, keep it for herself and justifiably say that she will release it in measured volumes to relieve suffocation of others for cash? Like air and water, land also is a basic need for human existence. It is on land that food is grown. Any one keeping it as owner, excluding others and saying that he will part with it on payment of money value, is wrong. This wrong has crept in some how or other and the poor had to suffer so much. To undo this wrong is Bhoodan Movement. The tiller must get the land, just like a thirsty man receives water to drink.

Land problem is not a new one. It is a very old one and requires a cautious approach for its solution.

Our country has an ancient culture and tradition. We have got our own ways to solve our problems. The Sarvodaya method is that way. A man who sees others suffering, feels the pain. He feels compassion. It is our ancient Dharma that makes us feel it is our duty to help the suffering and feed the hungry. Bhoodan movement is that same Dharmic approach to solve the land problem.

If Bhoodan land is offered to a poor agriculturist he will be relieved of his sufferings. And agriculture will improve. Let those who keep more lands with them, part the extra to such persons. If the workers tell the landlords 'the extra land with you will certainly be taken away a day, so give it now to Bhoodan' then the landlords will naturally give this reply 'let it happen, then we shall see'. If children are fed milk by force, they will shout and may even vomit what is forced in. Anything got done by force will certainly end in conflicts. If the Government takes land by legislation, there will be troubles. He who receives the land, instead of feeling really happy over it, will think that he has received only that which he is long entitled to. The person from whom it is taken away can have nothing but bitterness and disgust towards Government and society. On the other hand if a voluntary gift is made with joy there is happiness in the hearts of both the donor and the receiver in the very act. The donor at once feels the satisfaction and happiness that he has done a good thing and need not worry for *Moksha* in his

next birth. The joy of the receiver and the donor is the only permanent thing in the world.

Zamindari was abolished through legislation and the Zamindars are angry against the Government. The Rajas voluntarily relinquished their States. So the Government is sympathetic towards them. Gift is a free and voluntary act. The socialists are for land legislation. And the communists demand not only legislation but more than that and say that in case it is not done, they will use force. The ends for both are the same. But Sarvodaya desires to reach it through the means of dan (gift). This is what is known as Bhoodan Movement. It inspires compassion in the hearts of people. The feeling of compassion for each other is personified in Bhoodan.

There are many poor peasants in our villages with good experience in agriculture, who really desire to engage themselves in it. If they are given lands, production will increase.

Able young men inspired with the feelings of compassion and love should come forward to join the work and persuade the land-lords to give away the extra lands with them. They who possess lands know the difficulty to maintain them. They who have more than what they need find it still more difficult to manage. It is said in Tirukkural that land, if not properly cared for and maintained well, will repel its lord as the neglected wife behaves to her lord who proves irresponsible.

With caution and care the movement has to be carried on. There is the danger of violence creeping in if quick

and easy results are expected. Enlightened good men with *bhakti* in their hearts should come forward and do the work.

Distribution is indeed a difficult job. I would suggest that it may be done at the place as and when the gifts are received. Care must be taken that the new owners do not develop in them also the same kind of attachment that is found among the present land-owners. Government's help may also become necessary for distribution work. Land should be distributed among the deserving, experienced and enthusiastic peasants. It should also be given to those who have already bulls etc. with them for agricultural work.

You have the gem of a leader in Vinoba to guide you. And the cause is an undisputed one. Carry on your mission with all enthusiasm.



THE JOY IN GIVING

C. RAJAGOPALACHARIAR

In Bhoodan movement it is not the number of workers that counts; it is the character and quality that is important. Not because too many people come to persuade, the land-owner gives. And the land-owners in our country are able and clever. They are influential also. Only those who have strong influence and good character can prevail upon them to voluntarily part with land.

Untouchability movement has now got the force of law behind it. We have to continue the work to convert the minds of the people and it will help the Government. The desire to get things done with speed and hurry will create situations which may require the help of the police. The police way is not the workers' way. They should approach the people and try to convert their minds by slow degrees.

It was with great reluctance that I agreed to come and preside over this occasion. But now I feel immensely happy when I see these things before me. The land-owners freely offered land and the poor peasants received the same with joy. What a joyous sight? None ever expected before that such a thing could happen in this Kali Yuga. Has any one ever dreamt that such an event that the land-owners of this fertile land where the Cauveri flows will offer one acre each to the peasants as *dan*? These friends who have now distributed their lands are in all respects able and influential persons. They know how to earn, how best to spend and enjoy. They do not care for position or power or election. Such

persons coming forward and distribute their own lands as gifts to the poor agriculturists is indeed a miracle. I do not know what *Punya*, I have done to enjoy this scene before me.

Let more friends like these people come forward to offer and distribute lands. Let all people be happy. Let this movement of 'giving' grow and prosper. The donor is happier than the receiver. This is clear from his face. He will feel happier still when he looks more into it in future.

One can find happiness only in 'giving' and not in retaining. Of course there is pleasure in earning but in giving what is earned, there is greater joy. Only those who give, can experience this. Many may approach people 'to get' but few alone will come forward 'to give' of their own free will. And these few are the really great. I feel confident that those who have heard of this distribution will certainly come forward of their own accord in great numbers to offer and distribute lands in future. Let this movement grow big day by day. Let all become happy. The press, the platform and the organisation, all these of course, have got their important functions to play in Bhoodan. But the very basic of Bhoodan is non-violence and this has to be well grasped and remembered by the workers. Non-violence is not to usher in Bhoodan. But Bhoodan is to bring in non-violence.

Influences are of two types. One is that which the words of good men command and the other is the power of the people in position. Good and well-baked bricks are essentially needed to construct a good and strong house. In the same way non-violence is absolutely necessary for the success of this Bhoodan movement. On deep analysis I find that the objective of this Bhoodan movement is

the revival of the sense of Dharma in men, which they have now forgotten. An individual can possess property but he should hold it as a trustee for the benefit of the people. Gandhiji wanted this form of trusteeship.

It will be violence to distribute property through legislation. Those who have received land today will certainly produce more in the coming years. Increased production will make all people happy. The objective of Bhoodan is to secure through non-violent means the right for the poor experienced agriculturist to cultivate and produce.

Those who do agricultural work must get lands. This movement will succeed by itself if all the people in the village are made to feel that they are all one. The major effort of the workers should be to achieve this unity consciousness in the villagers. Going round the villages with loud speakers in jeeps and broadcasting high slogans will not help things much. The elders should be invited to help to create the desired atmosphere. They should be slowly persuaded to donate lands moved by compassion and love. The whole world is watching this movement. The question is not merely receiving land from one and distributing it to another. The objective is the creation of the real mental transformation in the people which will make each to do his Dharma. If her land problem is solved through love, India will shine as a guide to the whole world.

I pray that the workers may carry on the work along the right and proper lines.

(Summary of his speech on the 2nd day of the Sammelan.)



THE BASIS OF SARVODAYA

R. R. DIWAKAR

THE conception of Sarvodaya (good and progress of all) is a corollary of the doctrine of Satya and Ahimsa. Sarvodaya is a social conception. It is not a world connoting merely individual salvation. It means and includes the good of all, the progress and development of everyone constituting society. It is entirely inclusive and not exclusive, even of the worst and most wicked that may be found in society. It is a positive conception embracing the whole human family and binding it by ties of love which are far stronger and nobler than even those of blood.

‘Live and let live’ is a very common expression which means mutual tolerance in the extreme. But Sarvodaya is a step ahead and it would add, ‘Live and help live’. The right to live is supreme in Sarvodaya, and it is the right of every one. But a right does not and cannot exist without a corresponding obligation on somebody. A right can be exercised only vis-a-vis somebody who has the obligation to respect it, protect it and to see that it is exercised without let or hindrance. Thus accommodation for others, toleration of different points of view and ideologies is the very basis of Sarvodaya. And Sarvodaya comprehends all activities, economic, social and political. One can say that it extends to all planes of existence, namely, physical, vital, mental, moral and spiritual.

It is obvious that in a society based on the principles of Sarvodaya there is a moral obligation on each

individual to respect the other's rights and to see that everyone else has full scope to live, to express and to develop himself. It is grounded in the belief that all can develop and have full scope to develop in this wide world of ours.

Now there is possibility of aggression by those who do not hold this belief. Such aggression may range from disrespect for the rights of others to an attempt to eliminate and destroy the opponents. In such cases, Sarvodaya would recommend the sovereign remedy of Satyagraha. In fact, if truth and non-violence is a Siamese twin that Gandhian ideology has brought to the fore, Sarvodaya and Satyagraha constitute another twin that is inseparable. Satyagraha would resist all aggression, of whatever kind, by adhering to truth and by suffering and non-violence.

Looked at from another point of view and in terms of the society in which we live today, Sarvodaya means the initiation and establishment of a classless and casteless society by truthful and non-violent means.

Class-society is one based on economic, political, social and other inequalities. These inequalities give rise to iniquities through exploitation of 'haves' by 'have-nots'. All exploitation means taking undue advantage of one's own superiority and strength in some respect, with a view to some gain, personal or group. Such conduct is morally unjustifiable and wrongful. Moreover, exploitation is not restricted only to the field of economics and politics but it is found even in the spiritual field!



Bhoo dan or The Spirit of Sharing

J. C. KUMARAPPA

IN orthodox and in academic economics we read a great deal about production, distribution and consumption. But the more important aspect of economics that concerns Society as a whole is completely ignored. This is the essential aspect of sharing wealth between the various members of Society. Economics of production may be of interest until the time the producer has charge of his goods. Distribution to a large extent is still on the commercial level. Even in regard to consumption, the producers and others are only concerned with the disposal of the articles produced. Generally speaking, there is no pattern of consumption formulated by a philosophy of life. Advertisements usually restrict themselves to the meritorious performance on the desirability of the goods produced. But the aspect of consumption which is to be consciously inculcated in the public is often ignored. And even during production and consumption the social aspects are forgotten. Therefore it is well for us to consider this much-neglected aspect of economics - Sharing - for a few moments.

We shall have to tackle the deeper aspects of Sarvodaya which have not received the attention they should get from the academicians. John Ruskin, a British Philosopher, attempted in a very limited way to draw out the social bearing of the various elements like wages, cost, price, values etc. through discussion centering on these in his essays published under the title, "Unto This Last". The title of this book itself is

taken from a parable narrated by Jesus where He lays down the two fundamental ideas that work has to be found by Society for each individual and the needs of the individual worker must be taken care of irrespective of work itself, provided the work allotted is conscientiously carried out. Thus the separation of the work done from the wages paid leads to dealing with the fundamental problem of not viewing labour as a commodity. The whole of our Western economics to-day is built upon considering the purchase of labour as a commodity and taking it to be a part of the cost of raw materials themselves.

In this parable the lord of the Vineyard engages men to work in his Vineyard at different parts of the day and in the evening has all the workers paid the same rates as was agreed upon with the first batch. In this we see that the worker was given work at different times not because the workers were unwilling to work, but "No man had hired us", was the reason given. Under those conditions the workmen were entitled to their keep irrespective of the quantity of work done. Man is not a machine which works with a given amount of fuel for a given amount of work. This is the lesson drawn from this parable. That being so, the whole foundation of our present economic society, being based on dealing with labour as a commercial commodity, leads to violence. Therefore, in a Sarvodaya Society we have to reconsider the fundamental basis of our relations in the economic field. This records that man has a right to get his needs of life provided for him as long as he is prepared to utilise his time in the production of supplies needed by Society.

Similarly, the consumption pattern is also indicated in a parable which gives constructive worker and members of the Sarvodaya Society a programme of work in sharing life. This is also from a parable narrated by Jesus. He tells us at the last Judgement Day when God will separate the good from the bad he will recognise the services of those who had served him by feeding the hungry, clothing the naked, visiting those who were sick or in distress. God will regard these services rendered unto the least of these in need as service to Himself. This again is an indication that the fulfilment of our life lies in our sharing the good and the bad of human existence. Feeding the hungry may be taken as an indication of all that goes to fulfil the bodily requirements and clothing the naked will indicate the processing of raw materials for meeting human needs and healing the sick and visiting the needy will involve all that we can do to those who are not as well-placed in life as we are. This is a complete pattern of life laid down on principle.

We have to apply these principles to modern conditions. This calls for a spirit of Swadeshi that seeks to utilise the products of our fellow-citizens' labour, feeds him, clothes him and shares his life, giving employment in producing the goods and feeding the workers by consuming the products. Sarvodaya will include all this. It means sharing life with our fellow-men. When we use machine-made articles the machines have a share in our life, not our fellowmen.

Similarly when we hold more lands than we need in private possession we may be guilty of robbery in the same manner as when a person holds money in private

possession in great abundance. As I have been stating land cannot be held in private ownership, whether in large or small pieces. It is not the extent that is objectionable, but the ownership itself. All land should belong to the community as a whole, and given for proper utilisation to the workers for short periods of time. During that time the workers will themselves be subject to constant checking up.

Incidentally, I may say that planning should be with a philosophy of life, more of a fore-thought than be directed to control our action. From this point of view even the fixing of targets leads to attachment to the end and may influence the means, which may not be advisable. Our foresight should take into consideration the needs of the people, the type of food they eat, compared with the kind of nourishment they need in relation to the work they are called upon to do. These will lead us towards self-sufficiency and self-control while the present type of economics is based on the creation of new and unnecessary wants leading to self-indulgence, greed, jealousy and violence.

The spirit of sharing will lead ultimately to peace—contentment and brotherhood, while the present attitude to economic activity leads us to violence which runs into seed finally in the form of Atom and Hydrogen bombs.

One of the essential features of Sarvodaya is its remarkable flexibility in the sharing of human life. As has been said in the very beginning, the Economics of Enterprise, as developed in the West, regards itself purely as a Science of Wealth and even the little that has been contributed by Philosophers, like John Ruskin, to bring in certain considerations of human values in the

various mechanisms used by this system, such as, price mechanism, the working of demand and supply, and the functions of the middle men, all go to prove that the ultimate aim is efficiency of material wealth production. The race is to the fleetest, the back numbers get nothing out of such an economy. Sarvodaya as the name indicates should be the refuge of the weakest and the down-trodden. Therefore it calls for consideration, sympathy and love from the stronger members of Society towards the less fortunate.

This being so, in a Sarvodaya economy we would emphasise the human values in prices and cost rather than use them as guides in material production. John Ruskin proclaimed "Life is Wealth", while our economists will say "Material production is wealth."! The characteristic of the Capitalistic Economy is the self-gratification of indulgence and the pride of possession while the uniqueness of Sarvodaya lies in the doubling of joys by sharing our good things with others and halving our sorrows with the sympathy of our neighbours. This, of course, will mean a revolutionary outlook in economics. Are we prepared to change our approach towards material goods to strengthen our ties with our fellowmen? Unless this fundamental change is brought about by our changed attitude, it appears to me there will be no possibility of introducing any safety in the formidable situation that is now facing us with the manufacture of nuclear weapons. It seems Sarvodaya, with its sharing of life, is the only solution to material self-seeking with the consequent destruction of civilization. May we have the strength to meet the situation bravely!

(Speech delivered at the Sarvodaya Sammelan at Puri on 27—3—'55.)

India's Soul Is Astir

SWAMI ANAND

BY far the greatest experiment in the Gandhian way of tackling the country-wide economic and social problem in India today is the Bhoodan (Land-Gifts) movement. It is an attempt to usher in economic and social equality by calling upon owners of land (also property) to relinquish it and share it with the landless "have-nots" of the community on a voluntary basis and without recourse to legislation, which may follow in order to regularise what has already been accomplished.

The Movement has been initiated by Sri Vinoba Bhave, the foremost surviving disciple of Mahatma Gandhi. Originally an unorthodox monk steeped in Hindu lore, he has made a reverential study of world religions and their systems of ethics. Through years of intensive self-discipline and manual bread-labour he has slowly developed into a saint almost as tall in moral and spiritual stature as the Mahatma himself. His ultimate aim is Reconstruction of Man through applied non-violence in human relations, and doing away with all inequalities, economic or social, the world over. The Bhoodan or Land-Gifts Campaign in India is its local expression.

India, like America, is an agricultural country, over 80% of her 360,000,000 people having to subsist on land. Ours is thus an agricultural economy mainly. Vinobaji, therefore, has been calling upon all land owners in the country to share land voluntarily with the landless in every village without compulsion from society

or State, and by turning their villages into self-reliant, self-governing communes to establish the millennium.

In the three years since the launching of the Movement, Vinobaji has succeeded in securing over 33,00,000 acres from 3,00,000 donors, besides cash, implements and draught animals, which are being distributed among the landless. His target is to secure 50 million acres by way of these voluntary gifts before the year 1957 is out. His principal lieutenant in the campaign is Shri J. P. Narian, the great socialist leader of India, who is holding out a fair promise of becoming St. Paul of the New Faith.

The message is being delivered by the saint himself walking from village to village, holding prayer meetings, calling upon the "haves" to recognise the "sixth brother" and welcome him in the "joint family" with honour and status by conceding him land as his birth-right. The millions who listen to his words and witness these walking tours see in him Gandhi resurrected, having come back in their midst once more to fulfil his interrupted life-mission of reinstalling the "disinherited of the earth".

Thousands of social workers engaged in various constructive services of the Gandhian Programme have caught the spark of the New Faith and are carrying the flame to every nook and corner of India. At a recent convention held at Bodh-Gaya, the hallowed spot of Buddha's Enlightenment, and attended by the tallest in the land in the spirit of a pilgrimage, over 500 seasoned workers of both sexes responded to Shri Narain's call and solemnly pledged themselves to dedicate their lives to the great cause of man's reconstruction, by raising

a class-free, State-free society on the foundations of non-violence. Their number has increased considerably since.

These harbingers, in their turn, walk the villages 'carrying neither scrip, nor shoes, nor yet staves' chanting hymns prayer and of hope, assuring the millions of the millennium being at hand.

It is a unique phenomenon—these walking tours of the New Gospellers. The village folks,—both masters and men, the exploiter as well as the exploited,—hail them as apostles of the millennium. Without much persuasion and as if they were waiting simply to be approached, the "haves" part with their lands. They give with a joyous heart. They vie with one another. Often they give their all. The land gift is often accompanied by seed, implements and livestock, even stores and provision for the duration till the beneficiary is able to raise his "own" crop and harvest it.

While many big Zamindars owning vast acreage have bowed willingly, divesting themselves of a thousand or a hundred thousand acres apiece, the great bulk of the 3,00,000 donors hitherto registered are humble working folk holding a few acres or less each. Whole villages have come forward, donating every inch within their bounds and turning into co-operating fraternities. India's soul is astir. And her millions have come to know of it.

(From a letter written to an American friend—Sarvodaya Oct. '54)

ALL INDIA BHOODAN

Bhoodan Received and Distributed till 25th April '55

State	Acres received	No. of Dan Patras	Acres distrib- uted	No. of families
Bihar	23,30,555	2,89,515	21,123	11,364
Utter Pradesh	5,42,234	28,907	90,439	27,870
Rajasthan	3,45,816	57,814	7,762	1,511
Utkal	1,41,990	59,325	3,082	749
Hyderabad	1,06,898	4,010	32,019	6,862
Madhya Pradesh	99,237	20,097	34,180	5,692
Madhya Bharat	51,987	5,014	311	..
Saurashtra	41,000	15,000	1,500	..
Gujarat	37,578	8,426	3,235	1,011
Tamil Nad	32,467	5,835	530	161
Kerala	28,113	1,200	..	..
Maharashtra	28,000	4,500	1,001	..
Andhra	21,411	692	16	38
Punjab	12,650	3,046	325	66
Delhi	9,245	249	90	25
Bengal	9,732	4,738	1,168	957
Mysore	6,680	2,424	..	..
Vindhya Pradesh	6,198	1,209	650	255
Karnatak	2,803	538	..	..
Himachal Pradesh	2,025	66	..	..
Assam	1,950	..	..	..
Bombay	123	6	..	..
	38,58,692	5,12,611	1,97,431	56,561

Sampattidan-patras

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Printed at M. K. Press, Tanjore.